SUDDENLY:

MIRROR

A show about people who are suddenly confronted with who they are.

PROLOGUE

Ira Glass
From WBEZ Chicago, it's This American Life. I'm Ira Glass. And I am joined in the studio right now by one of my co-workers, Aviva DeKornfeld.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Hi, Ira.

Ira Glass
Hi, there. And so you're here to tell us a story.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Yes. It happened probably when I was 11 or 12. I was with my older sister, Ora, who's probably 14, and our cousin, Jake, who's 16 or so. He was visiting us. And one night we decided it would be fun to sneak into the community pool, which is just a few blocks away from our house.

Ira Glass
The community pool was closed?

Aviva DeKornfeld
Yes. It's probably midnight. Our parents are asleep. We'd never snuck in. So we're walking to the pool. And I actually didn't even want to sneak into the pool. I was scared, but I just-- the bliss of being included with the older kids as the younger one very much overrode my reservations.

Ira Glass
Absolutely.

Aviva DeKornfeld
So we get to the pool, scale the chain link fence, hop over, triumphant. Immediately, like one second after we've entered the pool, sirens go off. They're so loud. It's like, woo-woo. And then an automated voice comes on, and it's like, you are trespassing. The police have been alerted. They're on their way. Evacuate the premises.

Ira Glass
Right. And you guys are children, so--

Aviva DeKornfeld
So we panic. And my cousin, he is the oldest and tallest. And he just runs to the fence, hops over it, clears it no problem, takes off running. And then my sister is next. And she hops up on the fence, but then she kind of falls down. She doesn't quite make it over.

And then she hops up again, and she was just moving so slowly, in my mind. It was probably 15 seconds, actually. And what I did in my panic, is, she was up about 2 feet off the ground, holding on to the fence. And I grabbed her waist, and I ripped her off the fence. And I climbed over myself.

[LAUGHTER]

And I-- And it's the w-- we get home.

She's fine. She eventually makes it over. But for me, this is the first moment that I remember thinking, I have been shown what kind of person I am, and I am a very bad person. Or there is a part of me that is deeply selfish or capable of deep selfishness.

Ira Glass

Yeah. That's like a very grown-up thought to have. And there comes a time when you think that for the first time, right, you're 11, and you're capable of that.

Aviva DeKornfeld

Yeah. And what I saw was, this is who you are. You're the kind of person who prioritizes yourself over other people, including the person you love the most. My big sister was the person I idolized at the time, and we're still very close. But I was really like, anything for you. I love you so much. And then it turns out, actually, nope, I just want to save myself when I'm scared.

And the whole reason I'm here telling you this story is because I think that lots of people have moments like this and that these moments can act as a kind of mirror that reflect something back at you about yourself.

Ira Glass

And does this moment come back to you in the years since?

Aviva DeKornfeld

Absolutely. Every time I do something a little selfish or say something kind of shitty, or just, like, I have some sort of failure of kindness, I think back to this moment, and I'm like, well, that's the real you.

Ira Glass

Wow. OK, so the reason you're telling this story, I know, is that you have come here today with a collection of stories and moments like this one from a variety of people.

Aviva DeKornfeld

-eah.

Ira Glass

And with that, I'm going to just step out of the way and just hand over the show to you to host.

Aviva DeKornfeld

OK. Wait. Should I say,

"I'm Aviva DeKornfeld sitting in for Ira Glass,"or no?

Ira Glass

No, no, you don't have to do that because I think everybody's gotten that by this point.

Aviva DeKornfeld

They know who's who?

Ira Glass

[LAUGHS]

Yeah.

Aviva DeKornfeld

OK.

[LAUGHS]

Ira Glass

They have the cast of characters.

Aviva DeKornfeld

OK. Today on the show, we have stories, like mine, about people who are suddenly confronted with a part of themselves they had not previously known and how they deal with that newfound knowledge. Stay with us.

ACT ONE

On Top of Spaghetti, All Covered in Shame

Aviva DeKornfeld

It's This American Life. Act One, On Top of Spaghetti, All Covered With Shame. So that moment with my sister when I was 11, did it change me? I can tell you that I have never pulled her, or anyone, off a fence while running from the police again, not even once. But beyond that, no. I think this moment gave me a little window into myself, and that's about it. Fundamentally, I am the same person.

My coworker, Tobin Low, when I told him this story, he was like, well, yeah, I'm sure most people who have these split-second moments of selfishness don't really change. And to that, I say, what kind of world is that? Not one I want to live in. So I sent Tobin searching to see if he could find someone who had one of these moments and actually did change. I'll let Tobin take it from here.

Tobin Low

David and his girlfriend were fast asleep in his apartment in London when someone started banging on the door downstairs, screaming, fire. He got up and opened the bedroom door to find smoke piling in. And here is where he had his moment of split-second decision-making.

David

My first reaction was, OK, self-preservation. I'm going to get my passport because if that burns up, I'm going to be stuck here. I'm going to get my trousers because, again, I don't want to look foolish waiting downstairs in my underwear. And then I got my shoes. I ran outside. And I ran so vigorously, I ran up against a wall, and I got a burn, like a carpet burn, but from the wall. And I really wanted to get out of there.

Tobin Low

He made it outside. And it occurred to him only then that his girlfriend existed, and she'd also been in that smoke-filled room that he'd fled, passport in hand. He realized this because she was standing next to him. She'd made it out, too. But he had to admit to himself--

David

Oh, I'm glad she's safe, obviously, but I didn't have anything to do with that.

Tobin Low

His girlfriend, who's now his wife, says, I'm pretty sure I ran out ahead of you. He doesn't buy that, still beats himself up, says it's like a cloud of shame that follows him around. And yet--

Do you think it caused you to be the kind of person who runs towards a fire now? Do you think you're more of that person now?

David

I think no. I think I'm definitely-- I don't think I'm a hero.

Tobin Low

I put the call out in multiple places, talked to everyone I knew, wondering if I'd find a kind of superhero origin story, someone who took their pain and turned it into action. Turns out, there are many people out there haunted by the ghosts of split-second decisions past.

Jonah in Illinois-- one night, his girlfriend woke up with terrible food poisoning from eating a bison Sloppy Joe. She was suddenly and violently throwing up. He said he thought of helping, but instead, snatched the blanket off of her, threw it over his head, and ran out of the room. He said the smell was too terrible.

Tobin Low

Did it change you in some way?

Jonah

Um, no. No, I would say no. But I was a bit embarrassed, like ashamed that I didn't step up to the plate a little bit better. In my defense, it was extremely, extremely gross.

Tobin Low

To be fair to Jonah, I don't know that I would have stuck around for a repeat appearance of bison Sloppy Joes either, though there was a small pattern developing in my search results, a recurring theme of boyfriends making the, "wrong" decision, but not doing much differently afterwards. I wish I could report that it's going to change from here on out but here we go.

A lot of times, it was the girlfriends who wrote in to tell us what happened. There's Jana, who lived in bear country. One afternoon, a black bear charged. And what did her boyfriend do? He ran for his life, leaving Jana to fend for herself.

A similar thing happened to another woman, but instead of a bear, it was a charging bull. When she turned to grab her boyfriend's hand, she discovered he was already long gone, racing to the car.

Jenny in North Carolina-- she and her high school boyfriend were sneaking back into her house after curfew. Her stepdad thought it was an intruder and pulled a gun on them. What did her boyfriend do? He yanked her in front of him, used her as a human shield.

Tobin Low

Did you dump that guy right after it happened?

Jenny

Oh, absolutely not. No.

Tobin Low

They stayed together for five more years. And surprise, surprise, he was a jerk the whole time.

Jenny

It ended very tragically and heartbroken for me, which is funny looking back on it, because it was like, he was a really bad boyfriend.

Tobin Low

Talking to all these people, my search was coming up empty. Nobody seemed to be changing their behavior. They felt guilt, shame, embarrassment, sure, but actually changing? Not so much.

Then I talked to ***Becca***. Becca is a pharmacist who lives in Chicago. Her story happened while she was on a medical mission trip in Ethiopia. Her and her team were there working at a clinic.

It was the end of her stint. She was headed back to the airport from the village she had been working in. There was Becca, a paramedic, and this older volunteer couple, Frank and Sue. Before their flight, they sit down for a meal at a restaurant. They're starving. Everyone else gets burgers. Becca orders a plate of spaghetti.

Becca

And Frank just becomes unresponsive a little bit at the table. He didn't faint. He just was sitting there, staring into space and breathing heavily. And I just thought he was dehydrated. And I was like, Frank, here, drink this. Our food's here, and I'm so excited to eat. And then he's not responding to his wife. She's like, Frank, Frank. And he's just sitting there, labored breathing.

Tobin Low

Frank falls out of his chair, fully passes out.

Becca

And then the paramedic immediately jumps up, this huge, I don't know-- 6' 5", bulky guy, and he just throws him over his shoulder and starts running back towards the van and is like, come on, we're finding a hospital. And his wife is confused, but she's following and just like, uh, OK, what's going on? Is Frank going to be OK? Like, just frantic.

And I-- oh, this is so bad. I sat at that table like an idiot, trying to get the wait staff's attention to see if we can get to-go boxes for the food. And Cornell, the paramedic, is yelling, let's go. We have to go. I stand up, and I pick up my plate of spaghetti carbonara on a white porcelain plate with silverware, and take that with me into the van. So we're zooming away. Frank's in the back seat, for all we know, dying. And I'm holding this plate of spaghetti in the car.

Tobin Low

I talked to Cornell, the paramedic. He said, yes, he remembers her holding the plate of spaghetti while he performed CPR on Frank the entire ride to the hospital, and also feeling kind of like, OK, I guess I'm on my own here.

Becca

And I don't know why I did it. I don't know why I did it. I don't know why I did it. I was immediately so ashamed and so embarrassed.

Tobin Low

When did you eventually put the plate of spaghetti down?

Becca

[SIGHS]

When we got to a hospital. And I put this plate of spaghetti just on the seat, in the van, and we all went inside.

Tobin Low

Frank ended up being OK. They hooked him up to an IV. He felt better after a couple of hours. They got back in the van to head to the airport. And dear listener, if you're wondering if the plate of spaghetti was still there, if the driver of the van handed it back to Becca like a trophy of shame, if it sat on her lap because she was too ashamed to eat it in front of everyone else,

yes, that did happen.

Afterward, they joked that she was just looking out for them. She was just bringing them a snack.

Tobin Low
What do you think was actually happening in your head at that moment?

Becca
I think I was hungry and I wanted spaghetti. I think I was being really selfish. I really do. I think I was being really selfish. It doesn't sound good, right, when I say it.

Tobin Low
To me, it sounds like someone who went into shock. And you don't make rational choices when you're in shock.

Becca
But everyone else did. I think that's what still gets me. And I have since almost swung the other direction of trying to be so selfless. Just the other day, this woman fell in the middle of the road at the airport, blood everywhere. I drop all my stuff, run over there. I don't care about my luggage. I don't care about my stuff. Someone can steal my phone. I don't care.

I need to help this person.

Tobin Low
She's really trying to change. There are other examples. Like last year, when she was driving on the highway, when she saw a car accident, someone flung from their vehicle, she immediately pulled over, left her keys in the ignition, her dog in the back seat, just trying to get to this person to help. Becca is the only person I talked to who actually lives her life differently after reflecting on how she acted.

Becca
I'm trying to use that in a positive way, I think, now, because it's pretty gross, what I did.

Tobin Low
Do you think each time you're doing something like that, are you thinking about that plate of spaghetti on some level?

Becca
Honestly, I think maybe I am, somewhere in the recesses of my mind.

Tobin Low
I think we're tempted to think of these moments of panic as revealing our true nature. But really, that's just the animal part of your brain reacting on instinct. The stuff we do after those moments, when we apologize, or double down, or gaslight, or atone, that's the part that makes us human.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Tobin Low, he's an editor at our show.

ACT TWO

BWE: Big Wig Energy

Aviva DeKornfeld
Act Two, BWE, Big Wig Energy. You know those moments in life where everything's falling apart, and it feels like you're drowning? You've gone through a breakup. You've been laid off. And so you just grab on to the first log you see floating down the river, just so you have something to hold on to, like a rebound relationship or some new hobby you get way too invested in.

That's what Leisha did, which led her to trying on this whole new identity. It began when Leisha's best friend adopted a dog, and Leisha decided to buy a present to celebrate. Leisha's best friend is a hardcore Pittsburgh Steelers fan, so she decides to buy the dog a Troy Polamalu jersey. Troy was her friend's favorite player on the team, known for, among other things, his long, curly hair. Leisha finds a dog jersey, no problem.

Leisha Hailey
And I thought, oh, this would be great. I'll get the wig to go with this jersey. I went to all the pet stores. I looked online. And I could not find a wig. And I thought, well, this is like a void that needs to be filled. And I decided I was going to be the one to do it.

Aviva DeKornfeld
These days, pet wigs are everywhere. You can order one with next-day shipping. But this was back in the primitive days of 2014, before our culture had advanced quite that far. Leisha is good at lots of things. She's a musician and actress. You might recognize her from The L Word. But none of that translated to knowing how to make a hairpiece for a dog.

Fortunately, her sister is a hairdresser. So together, they bought a bunch of Styrofoam balls in three different sizes to represent the heads of small, medium, and large dogs. Then they bought some cheap wigs for humans to cut up and turn into prototypes. They came up with 10 different iconic hairstyles from throughout history. They made a mullet, a B52-style beehive, a gray Golden Girls wig.

Leisha Hailey
I had a Farrah Fawcett long, blonde flowing hair, feathered. I had a bob, like, "can I see the manager" kind of bob.

Aviva DeKornfeld
What's your favorite wig that you made?

Leisha Hailey
I think, for me, it was the beehive because it was so-- it was just the ultimate wig. It was fire-red. It had little sideburns that were curled, that came down. And it got funnier as it got smaller. It made a lot of sense on a pitbull, but when it went down to a chihuahua or a Pomeranian, it was hilarious. I think that was a big part of this, is that it was so silly and so joyful. It was enjoyable to wake up and think about. And that's a really nice thing to follow.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Leisha had had a really rough year before this. Her mom got sick. Then she went through a big breakup. Then she left the band she'd been in for the better part of 10 years, which meant she was also out of work. But now she had a mission. Leisha went all in on the pet wigs. Over the next few months, Leisha and her sister make 30 wigs, all 10 designs in each of the three sizes. She also got an LLC, opened a bank account. Of course, she needed a name for her product. She decided to keep it simple-- PetWigs, one word.

Leisha Hailey
I had a tagline-- it's a wig for your pet.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Very descriptive.
[LAUGHS]

Leisha Hailey
Well, you know--

Aviva DeKornfeld
If you didn't get from the name that it's wigs for pets.

Leisha Hailey
Exactly. Because that was always the second-- that was always the followup question, when I said I'm making pet wigs.

Aviva DeKornfeld
People would say--

Leisha Hailey
What is a pet wig? It's a wig for your pet. It was almost so shocking to people that they had to have that followup question. So I made it clear.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Three of Leisha's friends were living with her at the time. Their prototypes were always scattered around the living room, and all three friends got really into the project. One made a website. Another took over social media. The third signed her up for conventions, including DragCon.
Leisha was very excited about DragCon. She could show the wigs to people who really know and love wigs and find out if there's any possible market for them. So in preparation, she spent a ton of time building out her booth.

Leisha Hailey
It was beautiful. I just want to give it full props. It was a really great-looking booth. It was like a room you walked into. It was all white and clean. I had all the samples on a wall on shelves. And I remember I really wanted it to sort of feel like when you walk into the Apple Store. I wanted it to be clean lines, white walls, very stark. And then I wanted the pictures and the wigs to be the moment. So I wanted it to be top of the line, classic, like so high-- I wanted it to feel high-end.

The reaction that people had when they rounded the corner, people lit up in a way I've never been a part of. I've never seen people so happy.
[CHUCKLES]
I had a line out the door. I'm not going to say they were climbing over each other to get to it, but it was sort of rabid.

Aviva DeKornfeld
RuPaul himself even came by the booth. He loved the wigs. And it's then that something shifts for Leisha. Because it's one thing for your sister or your friends to like your idea, but when a stranger, clear-eyed in their total indifference to your well-being, when they tell you your idea is good, you believe it.
So, riding the high of DragCon, Leisha decides it's time to go big. She sets up an appointment with Walmart. She flies to Bentonville, Arkansas, home of Walmart headquarters. The building is hulking and corporate, with big glass doors and security guards, a far cry from her sunny living room littered with wigs. It's suddenly all feeling very official.

Leisha Hailey
It felt-- you know when Annie walks into-- in the musical, when Daddy Warbucks-- you know?

Aviva DeKornfeld
Mm-hmm.

Leisha Hailey
She walks into the house, and she's looking around. Like, almost like that. Like, am I going to like it here?

Aviva DeKornfeld
A rep meets her in the lobby, and they walk down this long hallway to his office, passing dozens of identical offices, each filled with other people pitching their products. Leisha said it felt like a factory. Leisha sits down opposite the Walmart guy, setting her bag of wigs next to her on the floor. She takes a deep breath and makes her pitch. She starts as confidently as she feels.

Leisha Hailey
One of the first things out of my mouth was, "I'm about to blow your mind."

Aviva DeKornfeld
This, unsurprisingly, was not the first time this guy had heard this. But then Leisha goes in for the hard sell.

Leisha Hailey
I think I talked a lot about the void in the market, the missing piece, the finishing touch to every costume out there, the billions of costumes that are sold every day to pets, to owners, all around the world, yet they're not completed. Because that was a real frustration of mine. It honestly was. It drove me crazy that you couldn't complete a costume.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Mm-hmm.

Leisha Hailey
He said, OK, let me see them. And I put them on the desk and presented my pitch deck. And the first thing he said was, great. I'd like to place an order. I think this would be great for Halloween. Let's launch at Halloween.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Oh, my god.

Leisha Hailey
I know. And right away, the questions started coming at me. How much can you make them for? Where are you making these? How are they packaged? How fast can you turn these around? Do you have insurance? Just on and on.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Of all the questions the Walmart guy asked you in your meeting, how many of them did you have answers for, would you say?

Leisha Hailey
Zero. *I had nothing.*

Aviva DeKornfeld
But how did you think that-- how capable were you of fulfilling the Walmart order?

Leisha Hailey
I had no means at the time to fulfill one wig order.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Not even one?

Leisha Hailey
Yeah. I would have called my sister back up and said, we've got to get cracking. I got some wigs to make. I just had the idea. I had a great idea.

Aviva DeKornfeld
All at once, the improbability of Leisha's whole scheme caught up to her. Until now, Leisha had been charging full speed ahead, never stopping to consider even basic questions of viability. But now, here was this Walmart guy forcing her to consider, for the first time, the reality of this project, which, frankly, Leisha had no interest in doing.

Leisha Hailey
I remember just wanting to take the wigs and put them back in my safe little bag with my great little ideas and zip it up, and just like, yeah, never mind, you know? You just want to--

Aviva DeKornfeld
Protect them from--

Leisha Hailey
--forget about it. Yes, from the horror of reality.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Because that's what he represented to you? He was like reality crashing and ruining the fun?

Leisha Hailey
100%. I think he just made me realize it was about to become very unfun very, very fast.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Yeah. And that was the point of it.

Leisha Hailey
That was it.

Aviva DeKornfeld
And with that, Leisha did what so many people fail to do. That little life raft she'd created for herself when things were rough? That log she jumped on? She jumped right back off. She didn't double down. She didn't marry the rebound relationship. Suddenly, she was able to see her pet wigs fever dream for what it was.

Leisha Hailey
It was sort of a strange fantasy bridge that I walked across for a year and a half. Because once it was over, things sort of normalized.

And the pieces of my life that I was used to started falling back into place. Yeah, I think I was better. I think I was done.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Leisha tossed the pet wigs into a bin in the shed behind her house, didn't think much about them. And after some time, she threw them away.

Aviva DeKornfeld
How did it feel when Halloween rolled around?

Leisha Hailey
The first Halloween, when I would walk through the pet aisles, I'm like, oh, they're still not here. I still don't see a wig.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Someone should really do something about this.

Leisha Hailey
Yes, someone should, right.

Aviva DeKornfeld
But it's not going to be me.

Leisha Hailey
Exactly.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Sometimes the reflection you see of yourself, it's just a mirage. There for a moment, then it disappears. And there you are again, the same person you always were.

When I was thinking about this theme, I remembered this story about this guy I went to college with. His name is Ari. We went to school just outside Los Angeles, and Ari moved to LA proper after graduation. One afternoon, the summer after he graduated, he was driving around.

Ari
I couldn't have been more brains off in this moment. I mean, I was just stuck in traffic, driving along the highway, and was just passively playing the radio.

Aviva DeKornfeld
Like zoning out, highway hypnosis.

Ari
Yeah. I was doing a drive like that, had done it a million times kind of thing.

Aviva DeKornfeld
He was listening to KCRW, one of the local public radio stations. And--

Ari
The DJ on the radio was just playing a lot of really good music, song after song. It was like, whoa.

Aviva DeKornfeld
What kind of songs were they playing?

Ari
I want to say, just a lot of things that were very popular in 2015. So like, indie pop. And I was just like, whoa, who is this DJ? And then they start back announcing the songs, which means after they play a couple songs, they have to do the credits.
And I just start having this picture in my head of who they are, like this classic idea of what I understood KCRW DJs to be like, which was a really cool woman who's single, in her late 30s, early 40s, has been on the alt scene for her whole career, has a short pixie cut. I don't know why.

Aviva DeKornfeld
So you're really imagining her.

Ari
Yeah. Yeah, I just saw it.

Aviva DeKornfeld
So Ari is driving along, feeling like he's found his radio DJ soulmate.

Ari
I was like, wow, this person has the exact same music taste as me. This is going to become a staple of my commute, catching their show. And this is going to be just the start of a rich, wonderful, one-sided relationship.

And after they back announce everything, they go, you're listening to the Frothy Indie Electronics Show with me, DJ Ari, here on KSPC. And I realized that the voice is me. And I mean, I was just so out of my body, floored because--

Aviva DeKornfeld
You're the lady.

Ari
Because I'm the lady, exactly.
[LAUGHS]

Aviva DeKornfeld
That's so weird.

Ari
Yeah. It was like reality broke for a second. How is it possible that I am hearing my own voice?

Aviva DeKornfeld
What had happened was this. Ari was not listening to KCRW. He had accidentally tuned to KSPC, our college radio station, where he had DJed as a student. And this set he was listening to was actually a rerun of a show he had done a few months prior.

This mistake he'd made, it was actually a version of a mistake that many, many people had made. You see, anytime Ari is on the phone with someone who doesn't personally know him, they always assume that he's a woman every single time. And that doesn't really bother him. It's not like he finds it insulting or anything. It's more, he just finds it confusing.

Ari
I don't see it, basically. I just don't hear this is something that I'm going to immediately presume to be a female voice, until I did, in the moment of hearing my voice on the radio.

Aviva DeKornfeld
It's cool that when you finally heard your voice as the rest of the world hears it, *you really liked it.*

Ari
Oh, hell yeah. *I was picturing the coolest person.*

ACT THREE

There Will Be Questions

Aviva DeKornfeld
Act Three, There Will Be Questions. This next story is about a dad who catches glimpses of himself in the questions his daughter asks him. The dad is comedian Mike Birbiglia, and he's been traveling around, talking about these questions on stage for over a year now. It's a pretty wide-ranging show. Here's an excerpt.

Mike Birbiglia
I'm walking my daughter home from school. And my wife and daughter and I live in Brooklyn, and there's all these smoke shops there. And they have these cutesy names like Blazy Susan and Yes, We Can-nabis. And *[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]* my daughter Oona looks up. She's nine years old. She looks up at the name of one of these shops, and she goes, Dad, what's The Good Life? And I was like, I don't even know.

[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER] It's not what I'm doing. And but then it was one of those moments where I'm like, oh, I should try to explain drugs as best I can. And I was like, well, some people use drugs, and they make your brain happy, but it's sort of a fake happy. *[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]*

And you don't want to get too happy because then you gotta use more drugs to get it as happy as it was the first time. And then the eighth or ninth time, you're in real trouble. Anyway, Mom and I use them sometimes. *[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]* Not often, mostly when we were younger. Not your age, like three years older than you are now.

[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER] But I use prescription drugs. I don't want to, but I have to because I have a serious sleepwalking disorder. The reason I bring up the sleepwalking is that 20 years ago, I get diagnosed with REM sleep behavior disorder, and they put me on Klonopin. And I recently went to a new doctor, and she's looking at my chart. And she goes, you've been on Klonopin for 20 years? And I go, yeah. She goes, all right. That was--

[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER] That is not what you want to hear when you go to the doctor. I go, are you concerned? She goes, well, do you know the side effects? I go, I don't know. She goes, depression, loss of memory, poor motor skills. I said, oh, I just thought that was my personality. It's a strange *[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]* moment in one's life when you realize your personality is side effects.

Because then I'm just self-conscious about all my daily activities. One thing I do every night before bed is my dosage of Klonopin is 1 and 1/2 milligrams. And so I have to break a pill precisely in half. Yeah, you know who shouldn't have a precision task like that? Someone with poor motor skills. Because inevitably, I **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** break it in half, and there's a pile of Klonopin dust on the sink. And I'm depressed, and I'm crying into the dust. And the tears are merging to form a Klonopin sorbet. And then I lick up-- **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** --what I perceive to be a half a milligram, but definitely isn't a half a milligram. So how do I explain that to my daughter? **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** **[APPLAUSE]**

That's the good life.

Yeah, that's what they're saying. There are so many things I feel like I can't explain to my daughter. She's nine years old. And it's just getting harder and harder. Because when they're younger, it sort of doesn't matter. They're an animated bag of rice, and you just gotta make sure they stay animated. And then, even when they're toddlers, it's a lot of layups. What's that? That's an egg. I'm a genius, you know. But-- **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** And my wife doesn't know that much stuff either. She's a poet. I'm a comedian. Together, **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** we're a sculptor.

We just don't know a lot. I mean, and it just started to become very clear to me about a year ago because I get a call from my mom. And she said, Dad was sick this week. And I tried to get him to go to his doctor, but he wouldn't go. And then yesterday, he fell down in the bathtub. And I called 911, and the ambulance took him into the ER. And it turned out he had had a stroke. And I get off the phone, and I'm alone in my bedroom. And then I go into my closet. I'm just sort of organizing things. And I just start crying, alone. And my daughter Oona comes in, and she goes, Dad, what's wrong? And I go, well, Grandpa had a stroke. And she says, Dad, what's a stroke? And that's when I **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** realized.

I can't really explain what a stroke is. I took a swing. I mean, I know the bullet points. I go, it's a brain injury, and there's bleeding in your brain. And then it was a lot of free association after that, you know. I was like, it's your **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** brain. Your brain is bleeding. And I'm not sure where the blood was, but I think it was in the vessels. And they're sort of all in there, you know? And but now, it's just-- it's everywhere. **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** I think. And maybe ask your mom about that or Grandpa, but not this week, you know? And-- **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** So Oona goes, is Grandpa Vin going to be OK? And I go, I don't know. I'm going to go home tonight. So that night, I drove to Providence, Rhode Island, to the hospital. And I take the elevator up to the eighth floor, to the stroke unit. And I see my dad, and he's just a shell of himself. He can't move half of his body, and he can't really speak. And the neurologist came in, and she goes, Vince, we're going to do a spinal tap. My dad happens to be a retired neurologist. So from the condition he was in, he suggested a type of spinal tap.

He goes, guided spinal tap, which is impressive, but also a good example of how controlling my dad is. I'm watching a half-dead neurologist tell a fully alive neurologist-- **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** --how to do her job. I mean, that is next-level mansplaining. I mean, that is-- **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** It was devastating seeing my dad in this condition because when I was a kid, I always viewed my dad as larger than life. He was almost like a mythological creature, you know? Just, in a way, I sort of wanted to be my dad because he knew so much stuff. He was a doctor, and in his free time, he got his law degree. Yeah. That's how much he didn't want to be a dad. He was like-- **[APPLAUSE]** **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** He was like, what can I do in these slots of time when I would be parenting? In fairness, we weren't great kids. We always wanted a dad. **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** And he wanted another secondary degree. So our goals were at odds. **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]**

My dad was a doctor, but I didn't really see him that way, you know. Every once in a while, when I was a kid, strangers would come up to me. They'd be like,

*(**BOSTON ACCENT**) your dad is a great doctor!*

And all right, you know? From Worcester, Massachusetts, that's how everyone talks.

[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]

*(**BOSTON ACCENT**) Your dad is a great doctor.*

[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER] It's like, we don't-- none of us fully understand what our parents do when we're kids. It was rare that I saw my dad as a doctor. I remember a couple times-- I played soccer when I was a kid. I was the goalie. And one time, I dove head-first for the ball. And I got to it. And then the kid on the other team kicked my head-- I know-- with the intensity he had intended for the ball. And I don't know the rest of the story.

But I have **[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]** been told that I hopped up, and I was like, I'm good. *[**CHUCKLES**]* And they took my word for it, and they kept me in the game. And about 15 minutes later, I just wander off the field. **[APPLAUSE]** --onto another field. **[APPLAUSE]** And my teammates ran over. They go, Mike, are you OK? And I said to them-- and I quote-- I go, what are we even doing here?

And my dad ran onto the field. And he picked me up, and he carried me off. And he drove me home. And he asked me all the questions that doctors asked their patients. What's your middle name? What are the classes you take at school? And I was like, oh, OK, this is what my dad does.

And then the other time when it came up is that I went to St. Mary's School for grade school in Shrewsbury, Massachusetts. And every Friday night, we had science club, which is kind of like a mafia front for Catholic school. Like,

*(**BOSTON ACCENT**) we believe Jesus turned water into wine, and also, there were dinosaurs, you know. And--*

[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER] So every Friday night, it's like a different parent explaining what science has to do with their job. And one night, it was going to be my dad, and I was so nervous. I was like, what's he going to say? He doesn't know anything about science. And he came in, and he brought his medical tools. And he took them out one by one. He explained what each of them does. He took out a three-dimensional model of the brain and explained the hemispheres of the brain. And all these kids came up to me afterwards, and they were like, your dad is wicked smart. You have the smartest dad. I was like, yeah, I do have the smartest dad. But how come he didn't explain any of that stuff to me sooner?

Because I just didn't see a lot of that, you know? What I would see of my dad was, he'd come home from work around 8 o'clock at night, and he would sit in the corner of the living room and read a war novel and scowl.

And every now and then, he'd sort of fly off the handle about some little thing.

He'd be like,

*(**SHOUTING**) where are my goddamn keys?*

I'd be like, we gotta find Dad's keys! I spent my whole life looking for ***[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]*** those keys. So we'd look for the keys, and then my mom would just pray, you know. She'd be like, I'm going to say a prayer to St. Anthony. I was seven. I was like, I don't think this is going to work. We need more concrete tactics to locate the keys. My dad would ***[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]*** not like that joke. No, my dad doesn't like a lot of my jokes, but he particularly doesn't like it when they're crude, and then also personal. And he doesn't like political jokes.

As a matter of fact, when I was in my 20s, I was doing a political joke, and then we ended up having this discussion from it about politics. And it was tense. I was visiting him, and we went for a walk on this wooded path behind his house. And the farther we walked, the more tense it got, to the point where he was just saying mean-spirited things about me. And then I started saying mean-spirited things about him.

And I got back to my car, and I said, bye, Dad. And he didn't say goodbye. He goes, well, you've gone another way. And that was it. And I just drove home. And I just felt so adrift. I thought my whole life, I sort of wanted to be my dad. And at a certain point, I decided I wanted him to be me. So I'm with my dad in March at the hospital, and it's devastating. I mean, if you've been with someone who's had a stroke, I mean, it's the worst thing you can possibly imagine. But I will say, if I'm being completely honest, it has calmed him down.

Stay with me. Most of the jokes are for you, but a few of them are for me. This is- ***[AUDIENCE LAUGHTER]*** -This is a coping mechanism. I hope it is for you, too. I mean, most of the time, this is horrific. But then every once in a while, I'm like, where was the stroke when I was five? You know what I mean?

We need more concrete tactics to locate the keys. My dad would not like that When I was a kid, he'd be like,

*(**SHOUTING**) where are my goddamn keys?*

Now he's like,

keys.

And I'm like, I can't say I don't prefer the latter. It is a little more polite. So I'm with my dad in March at the hospital, and then he can't even really move his face. And so the only way I can even understand his expression is through his eyes. And the expression in his eyes is fear. *So how do I explain that to my daughter?*

Aviva DeKornfeld

Mike Birbiglia. This was an excerpt from his brand new comedy special, The Good Life. It comes out this week, Monday, the 26th. Go watch it.

ACT FOUR

Trouble Afoot

Aviva DeKornfeld

Act Four, Trouble Afoot. As you've heard many, many times in today's show, how you behave in a crisis, sometimes it shows you who you really are. That can be true even with a very small crisis. Here's David Kestenbaum.

David Kestenbaum

The story starts with a shoe that one day seemed to stop existing. It was a gray and white Adidas, belonging to one Ruby Gans, age 24. Ruby had worn it and its mate to work, like she did just about every day. She's not a person who has a lot of shoes.

At the end of the day, she switched to her running shoes to go for a run with a friend. The Adidas, she stuck in her car. After the run, she drove home, then reached over to the back seat, where she'd put the shoes.

Ruby Gans

And there's only one shoe. And so, I did my best. It was dark at that point. So I did my best to sort through the car and look under the seats.

David Kestenbaum

Still, only one shoe. It was weird to lose just one. The next morning, she looks everywhere-- around the car, on the sidewalk. This is in Santa Barbara, California. She texts her parents, who live nearby, "I seem to have lost a sneaker." Her dad texts back, "Have you looked on your feet?" Ruby-- "I have looked on my feet." Dads. She rechecks the car.

Ruby Gans

I even-- I did the whole deep cleaning thing where you take out all the carpets.

David Kestenbaum

Because it has to be somewhere, right?

Ruby Gans

Yeah, totally.

David Kestenbaum

Ruby is a science type, works in a lab. So she comes up with a working hypothesis. She figures she had dropped the shoe getting into the car, and the street sweeper had come by and swept it up, which would explain why it was nowhere. Case closed. She kept the one lonely sneaker, just because hope.

Ruby Gans

It's a new month. I have a new basic pair of shoes that I wear every day. It's a pair of black Doc Martens. And I knew that I had those shoes in the car. I was getting ready for work. I got out to the car, and I could only find one shoe. I was just completely shocked and confused because how could this have happened not once, but twice? I don't know anyone who has ever lost one shoe. And now it's happened to me twice. This just is not possible.

And I looked around, I mean, pretty thoroughly, checked everywhere I could think that a shoe would fit. And there was only one shoe in the car. And I was-- I mean, I would say panicked is too strong, but I was worked up about it. This is not a thing that happens in real life. Where is my shoe?

David Kestenbaum

I was into Ruby's story. I find losing things to be completely maddening. Objects cannot just disappear. Here's what I want. I want, when you die, for them-- and I don't know who I mean by them-- to tell you where everything you lost over the course of your life actually was when you were looking for it.

Anyway, Ruby, who is wired similarly, decides she is not going to work until she finds this shoe. Her hunt begins with deduction. She feels sure it was in the car yesterday, which meant it must have fallen out of the car, which feels kind of unlikely now that I say it. Did the shoe hurl itself out somehow?

Anyway, she makes a list of every place she had gone the day before. She'd gone to a city office to file a form. She'd gone to a Trader Joe's. And she'd gone to work. So she checks all these places. The parking lot at the city office-- no shoe.

The Trader Joe's-- actually goes into the Trader Joe's and asks the manager, did any workers find a single shoe in the parking lot? No. She texted the facilities guy at work, who texts her back a laughing face emoji and no, no shoe. She also goes to look at her boyfriend's house, where things took a turn.

Ruby Gans

And I went and I looked all around the house, didn't find the shoe. But I did find his dad, who had showed up. And his dad was like,

have you considered that someone's messing with you?

And I was like, no, I had not considered that. But you're right, I should.

David Kestenbaum

He'd just mentioned it in passing, but suddenly, things made a lot more sense. The question was, who was it? It had to be someone who knew about the first shoe and how crazy that had made her, who had then taken the second shoe as a kind of prank. There was a short list of suspects, maybe a friend at work. There are cameras in the parking lot. She could ask the facilities guy to go through them. Or maybe, actually, her boyfriend-- it would have been easy for him to grab her car keys.

Ruby Gans

I texted him saying, be straight with me. Are you messing with me? Do you think someone else is somehow messing with me? Is there a way to tell if someone broke into my car? He's a car guy, so.

David Kestenbaum

She waits a minute. He texts her back.

Ruby Gans
"I am not the one hiding your shoes, if that's what you're asking.
I don't like pranks, and I wouldn't do that. If someone's doing that, it's not funny to me."

David Kestenbaum
It wasn't funny to her either, but anything was starting to seem possible at this point.

Ruby Gans
I was starting to feel a little bit genuinely concerned. It didn't really process at first, but then once I was thinking about it, I realized that would mean somebody is getting into my car, and that makes me pretty uncomfortable. And I'm starting to feel kind of afraid.

David Kestenbaum
Ruby wonders, should I call the police? She drives home from her boyfriend's house, sits on the front steps, when a thought occurs to her. And that thought is, wait, yesterday, didn't I come home for 10 minutes? I did. And didn't I park over there? She gets up, walks over to that spot.

Ruby Gans
I looked in the street. I looked in the gutter. It wasn't there. And I was like, ugh, OK, fine. But then, I looked up.

David Kestenbaum
And there, in the tree, was her shoe. I'm kidding. It was a few feet away, on a curb next to someone's yard. It looked like someone had helpfully picked it up and set it off to the side.

Ruby Gans
And I was so relieved. I was relieved beyond words to see the shoe sitting there. I took a picture of it.

David Kestenbaum
So many things were put right in that moment. It was confirmation that objects do not suddenly stop existing and disappear. And also, the world was suddenly repopulated in her mind with people who were generally kind and helpful.

Ruby Gans
It was really nice to swing from thinking that a stranger is trying to break me psychologically to, oh, a stranger picked this up for me.

David Kestenbaum
It was still a little crazy-making that the first missing single shoe was unaccounted for. But then a few days later, she was walking her parents' dog, and it jogged her memory. She'd parked in that very spot she was walking the day she had lost the shoe. It was after the run, but before she went home. She'd just forgotten. And there it was, beside the road, the gray and white Adidas. She was back in the world she had started in.

David Kestenbaum
It's interesting how quickly you went to seriously considering the least likely things, you know?

Ruby Gans
Yeah. I immediately started thinking about all the crazy-- all the things that people believe and I think are crazy. I'm like, pfft, that could never happen to me. I'm way too smart and logical.

David Kestenbaum
Actually, it was logic, a kind of logic that led you there, right?

Ruby Gans
Yeah. Maybe I would have thought that I was somehow superior or just-- I don't know. Turns out, I'm not.

David Kestenbaum
If you are listening to this and feeling a little disappointed, like you were promised a plot twist, something exciting and more dramatic than a story about a woman who had just lost two shoes in a row, because that is what you come to this show for, fair enough. But I am just holding up a mirror to the real world, where *sometimes a lost shoe is just a lost shoe.*